

The Sicilian Alapin b4 Gambit: An Opening Monograph and Complete Repertoire

Owen Reich

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Part I

Introduction

1: Who Is This Monograph For?

This monograph is for chess hobbyists, online rating grinders, club players, and opening enthusiasts. The Alapin b4 Gambit is not a bold, forcing refutation of the Sicilian, nor does it replace the established Sicilian lines. It is a practical weapon to create unfamiliar positions and challenge opponents with difficult decisions from move three.

Readers should be familiar with standard opening tactics, Sicilian motifs, and algebraic notation. Many of the ideas can be understood by improving players, but players rated 1000-2200 looking for a surprise weapon against the Sicilian will take the most away from it (particularly the upper range of the spectrum, where the Sicilian is more common).

This monograph emphasizes plans, preparation, recurring themes, and practical chances in addition to engine analysis. We will look not only at Black's best move but Black's most obvious move. Many of the positions are extremely rare (most have not been reached at all), and as a result the strategic ideas behind the opening are more important than rote memorization.

Players seeking a quiet positional game or theoretically established main line will prefer other openings. Players looking for a "one size fits all" trap to win games in 5 moves will also prefer another opening. *This monograph is written for players who value practical chances and original positions over theoretical consensus.*

2: Introduction to the Gambit

This gambit stems from the Sicilian Alapin, a popular response to the Sicilian for White. After the Alapin is reached, we don't play the usual d4, but instead play b4. We gambit a pawn for a huge center and opportunities to kick around Black's misplaced knights. After

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4

our unusual gambit is accepted. We use b4 to redirect the pawn on c5, and we take the center with d4. Black has a couple of responses to this, which include some positional traps which give us a huge center and opportunities to kick around Black's misplaced knights.

Move	Frequency %	# Of Occurrences	Theory
bxc3	69%	2.4k	Part II, Page 6
d5	11%	395	Part III, Page 26
e6	10%	345	Part IV, Page 27
d6	3%	88	Strategy A
e5	2%	63	Strategy A
g6	2%	54	Strategy A
Nf6	1%	42	Strategy A
Qa5	1%	31	Play Bb2
a5	< 1%	15	Strategy A
Qb6	< 1%	15	Play Be3
b3	< 1%	11	Play axb3
a6	< 1%	8	Strategy A

Table 1: Data acquired from [2] illustrating the rarity of this gambit. All of these games were Bullet or slower, with an average rating of ≥ 1000 .

In this monograph, I will examine Black's responses from most common to least common. This gambit has been played roughly 3,500 times in Lichess history at the time of writing, so several of these lines are so rare that practical data is limited. Even so, each branch reveals important ideas, and I will go through them in detail, particularly with the main line of bxc3. All evaluations were performed with Stockfish 18. Some themes of important lines were explored by making Stockfish play itself from the position. To start, we will focus on the fringe responses to the opening moves. Strategy A means to play 5. d5 and later Nf3 and press our space advantage. In the Qa5, Qb6, and b3 responses, simply play the move labeled in the **Theory** box and you will have a somewhat standard yet sharp game ahead of you.

3: Analysis Methodology

All analysis was performed with Stockfish 18 [3] in the En Croissant [1] GUI. We will frequently include the evaluation of a line and the depth of analysis that led to that evaluation next to a PGN. We have also included a Key Ideas field next to each main line for a quick memory refresher or for skimming if you do not want to go in depth. These Key Ideas were developed by setting up the positions in En Croissant and letting Stockfish play against itself. The recurring motifs that emerged from those games are summarized for quick reference.

Part II

Main Line: 4. bxc3

Stockfish says that after completing our setup we are down -0.61 after thinking 50 moves ahead. However, if Black takes our pawn on c3 too, they immediately lose all the advantage. The opening creates a very sharp game in which both sides are rated exactly equal. So far our opening should go like this:

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3
```

Evaluation: 0.00 **Depth:** 50 Moves

We are down a pawn, but we have 2 pawns in the center, as well as a developed knight and an open bishop. We have some ideas that are similar to the Danish Gambit, like placing our light squared bishop on c4, dark squared bishop on a3, and our queen on b3 to dominate the a2 - g8 diagonal, creating some deadly kingside attacks.

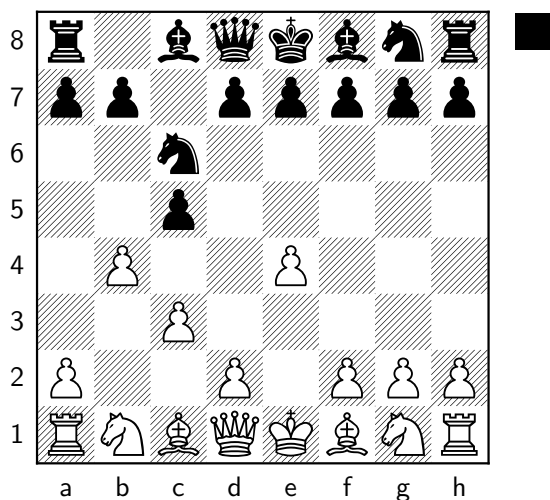


Figure 1: White plays 3. b4, offering the gambit.

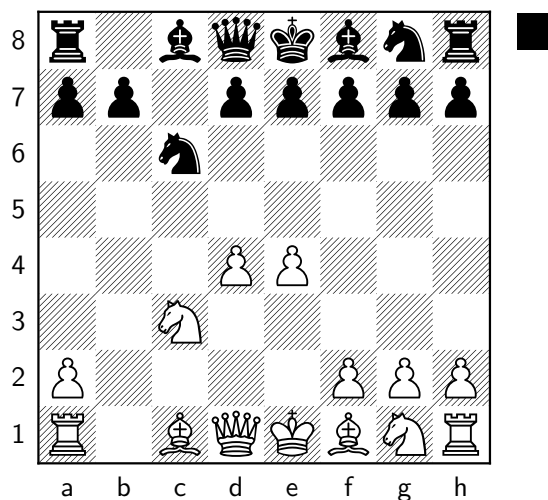


Figure 2: Black accepts, and White has central dominance.

Black's most common responses from here are e6, d6, g6, and e5, followed in popularity by the blunderous Nf6, d5, and Qa5. The former four lines will be covered in detail as they are the most common and the sharpest lines. The latter three lines will not be covered in detail as they are all easily punishable mistakes by Black, but we will cover how to beat them.

1: Main Line: French Variation

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6

Evaluation: 0.00 **Depth:** 50 Moves

Key Ideas: Push d6, focus on Rc1, and exploit the fork threat on c7. Attack the queenside while keeping the kingside safe.

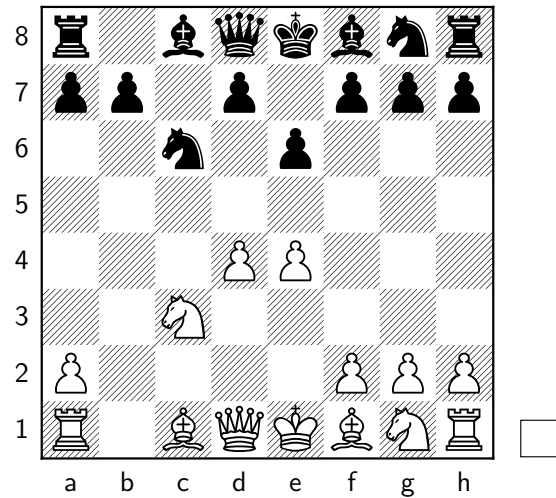


Figure 3: The French Variation of the Main Line

Black's idea in playing e6 is to (a) open up the queen and bishop, and (b) to set up a pawn break with 6. d5. Our response to their pawn break is to completely turn off d5 by playing d5 ourselves. Black's most accurate response is to create a counter threat by playing Qf6. This not only attacks our knight but also can create some checkmate threats with the dark squared bishop. However, if after playing d5 they take our pawn with exd5 it gives us a slight advantage. We take back with our e4 pawn.

1.1: Main Line: Knight Variations

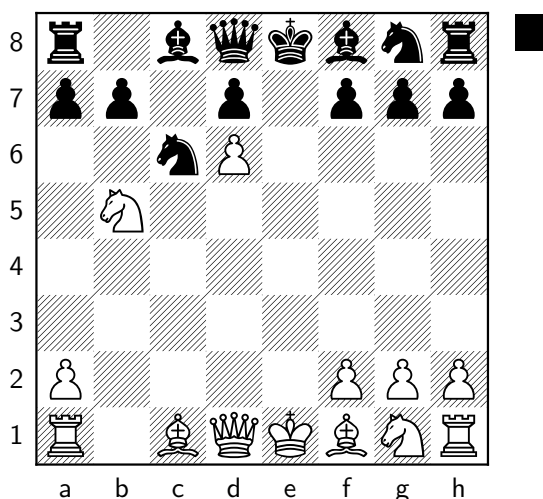
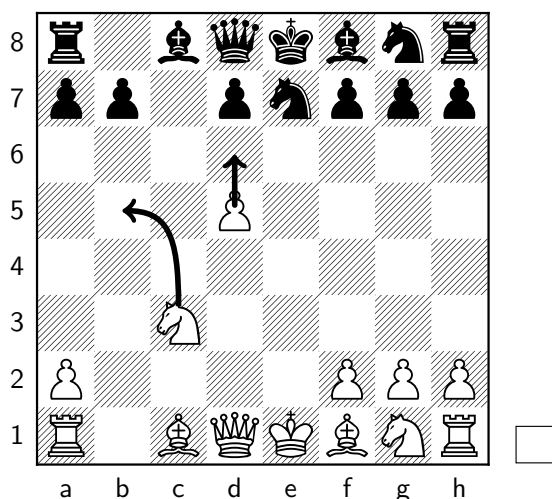
1.1.1: 7. Nce7 Variation

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 exd5 7. exd5 Nce7

Retreating the knight is actually a blunder here. We push the pawn to d6, kicking out their knight. They will most likely go back to c6, Now we reveal why retreating was a blunder. Nb5 is the killer move, threatening a fork on c7 and supporting the pawn on d6. We also can move our Queen to e2, and Black must block with the bishop. We take with the pawn, securing material and an easy win.

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 exd5 7. exd5 Nce7 8. d6 Nc6 9. Nb5

White is much better because Black simply has no way to defend White's 2 threats.



1.1.2: 7. Nb4 Variation

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 exd5 7. exd5 Nb4

If Black plays Nb4, we play Nf3, and their knight is almost trapped. It's only square is a mistake, as if it goes to a6 we trade the light squared bishop and we capitalize on our pinning and forking potential as we saw in the last line. Our main goal here is to get the pawn to d6 and the rook to c1, as if we can do this we place dangerous pressure on c7 as well as stifle their bishop's development.

1.1.3: 7. Na5, 7. Ne5, and 7. Nb8 Variations

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 exd5 7. exd5 Na5 OR Ne5 OR Nb8

If Black plays either of these three moves, we play d6, claiming even more space. Their bishops are locked into their starting squares with no hope of escape, and unless they pin with either the queen and the bishop we can capitalize on the fork we saw. If they do pin, we play Bb2. We control the center, have pieces developed, Black is cramped and their bishops cannot escape. Ne5 example line:

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 exd5 7. exd5 Ne5 8. d6 Qa5 9. Bb2

And here, White is better.

1.2: Main Line: Bb4 Variation

This is one of the most accurate moves for Black, as they can't respond to our threat by saving their knight. They also threaten to take the knight with check, winning tempo and forcing us to

respond. They also take away our powerful knight which threatens the fork. We reply with Bb2.

1.2.1: Trade Variation

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 exd5 7. exd5 Bb4 8. Bb2 Bxc3+ 9. Bxc3

If they take our knight with Bxc3 then we play Bxc3, threatening to win the rook with Bxg7. Their knight is still threatened by the pawn, so they must choose which threat to deal with. So this becomes a +3 advantage for White instantly.

1.2.2: Retreat Variation

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 exd5 7. exd5 Bb4 8. Bb2 Nce7

In this line, our best move is 9. d6 which forces Black to move their knight.

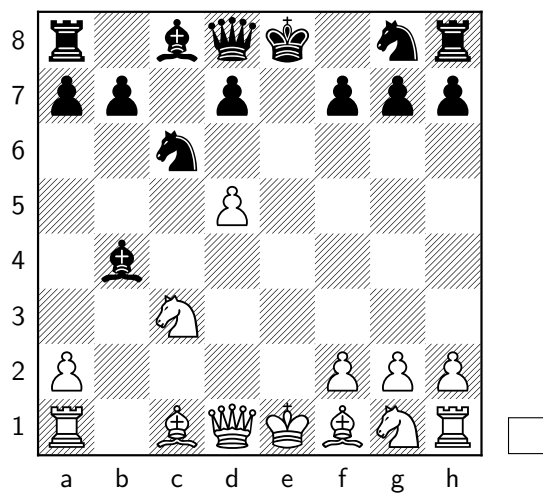


Figure 4: The Main Line Bb4 Variation. (Section 1.2)

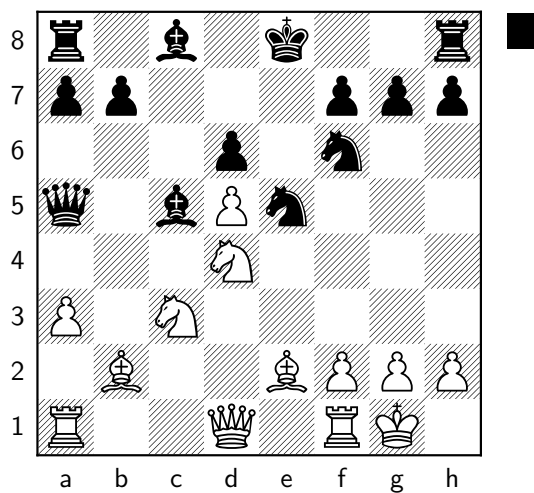


Figure 5: An example of a midgame following the Retreat Variation. (Section 1.2.2)

1.2.3: 9. Nc6 Variation

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 exd5 7. exd5 Bb4 8. Bb2 Nce7 9. d6 Nc6

Responding with 9. Nc6 is bad because of 10. a3 Ba5 11. Nf3. We have a +1.5 advantage:

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 exd5 7. exd5 Bb4 8. Bb2 Nce7 9. d6 Nc6 10. a3 Ba5 11. Nf3

1.2.4: 9. Nc6 Trade Variation

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 exd5 7. exd5 Bb4 8. Bb2 Nce7 9. d6 Nc6 10. a3 Bxc3+ 11. Bxc3

If they trade, we take with the bishop and while they play 11. Nf6 to protect the rook we play 12. Bd3. We have an excellent attacking position with the open E file. If they choose to castle kingside we have some deadly bishops, and castling queenside poses problems due to the lack of a c pawn defending their king.

1.2.5: 9. Qa5 Variation

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 exd5 7. exd5 Bb4 8. Bb2 Nce7 9. d6 Qa5

After we attack the knight with 9. d6, the most accurate reply for Black is to play 9. Qa5, doubling down the pressure on our knight. We play 10. Ne2 to protect our knight on f3.

1.2.6: 10. Nf5

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 exd5 7. exd5 Bb4 8. Bb2 Nce7 9. d6 Qa5 10. Ne2 Nf5

Black must play 10. Nf5, a difficult move to find. Most people will play Nc6, and you can use that mistake to attack on the kingside. The difference is the knight on c6 has a hard time defending the kingside while putting the knight on f5 lets the knight defend much more easily.

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 exd5 7. exd5 Bb4 8. Bb2 Nce7 9. d6 Qa5 10. Ne2 Nf5 11. a3 Bc5

White is slightly better. If instead of 11. Bc5 they play 11. Bxd6 then we can punish this mistake by playing g4, and we will eventually win a piece tactically.

1.3: Main Line: French Variation — 6. Qf6

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 Qf6

The idea behind 6. Qf6 is to support a knight push to d4. Our best defense is not to take the knight on c6 with our pawn, but to play Bd2 to protect our knight on c3. Our move also connects the rook and queen, meaning the knight is no longer pinned. Black continues their plan and plays 7. Nd4. Now we play 8. h4, preparing Bg5. We will try to kick the queen to make use of the poorly defended knight that Black placed in our territory. Black has 2 options for defending their knight. Their 2 options are playing 8. exd5 or 8. Bc5. We will look at them now:

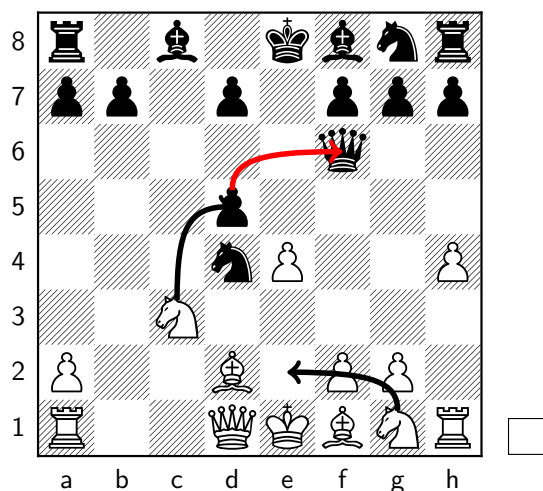


Figure 6: Black's exd5 response, which is a mistake. (Section 1.3.1)

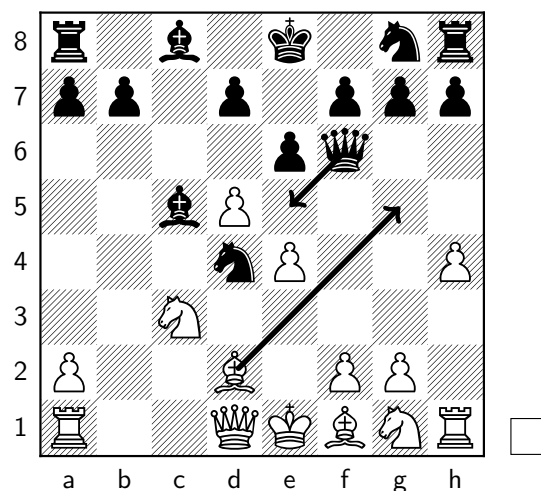


Figure 7: Black's Bc5 response, which is optimal. (Section 1.3.2)

1.3.1: 8. exd5

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 Qf6 7. Bd2 Nd4 8. h4 exd5

This option isn't good for Black. However, do not make the mistake of playing Bg5, which is countered with Bb4! Our most straightforward option is to take back with the knight and to play like this:

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 Qf6 7. Bd2 Nd4 8. h4 exd5 9. Nxd5 Qd8 10. Bc3 Ne6

Alternatively, we can play 9. Nge2 to challenge the knight. If Black trades, we will play:

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 Qf6 7. Bd2 Nd4 8. h4 exd5 9. Nge2 Nxe2 10. Nxd5 Qd8 11. Qxe2

If Black does not trade, we will play like this:

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 Qf6 7. Bd2 Nd4 8. h4  
exd5 9. Nge2 Bb4 10. Rc1 Nxe2 11. Bxe2
```

This option is worse but more subtle than taking back with the knight, and it may lead to more mistakes for Black.

1.3.2: 8. Bc5

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 Qf6 7. Bd2 Nd4 8. h4  
Bc5
```

This option is much better than defending with the pawn. Moves that don't lose are much easier to find for Black than in the pawn variation. We play 9. Bg5, the whole reason why we played 8. h4. The Queen only has 2 squares to go to, and they are e5 and g6. 9. Qg6 doesn't lose on the spot, but it is slightly worse than 9. Qe5.

1.3.3: 9. Qg6

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 Qf6 7. Bd2 Nd4 8. h4  
Bc5 9. Bg5 Qg6 10. Nf3 Nxf3+ 11. Qxf3
```

This line is fine for Black if they play the correct move, 11. Ne7. However, if they play 11. Nf6 we get an advantage.

1.3.4: 9. Qg6, 11. Nf6

Here 11. Nf6 is a mistake. The reason is:

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 Qf6 7. Bd2 Nd4 8. h4  
Bc5 9. Bg5 Qg6 10. Nf3 Nxf3+ 11. Qxf3 Nf6 12. e5 Nh5 13. Bd3 f5 14. exf6 Qf7 15.  
dxe6 dxe6 16. Bb5+ Bd7 17. Bxd7+ Qxd7 18. Qxh5+ g6 19. Qf3
```

After 11. Nf6 we play e5 to kick the knight. Then we attack the queen so she has to block with the pawn. We play en passant, and the queen has to run. We keep taking pawns, until we are up 3 points of material and we have a powerful passed pawn on the 6th rank. Even if Black plays the best move after 11. Nf6, we still end up with a +3 advantage according to Stockfish.

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 Qf6 7. Bd2 Nd4 8. h4  
Bc5 9. Bg5 Qg6 10. Nf3 Nxf3+ 11. Qxf3 Nf6 12. e5 h6 13. Bd3 Qh5 14. exf6 Qxf3 15.  
gxf3 hxg5 16. fxg7 Rg8 17. Ne4 Bb4+ 18. Ke2 Rxg7 19. Hxg5
```

So Nf6 is a mistake. The best move for Black is 11. Ne2.

1.3.5: 9. Qg6, 11. Ne7

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 Qf6 7. Bd2 Nd4 8. h4 Bc5 9. Bg5 Qg6 10. Nf3 Nxf3+ 11. Qxf3 Ne7 12. Bd3

From here we attack with our active pieces or try to squeeze out a winning endgame. We have a very slight +0.3 advantage.

1.3.6: 9. Qe5

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 Qf6 7. Bd2 Nd4 8. h4 Bc5 9. Bg5 Qe5

If Black plays 9. Qe5 we respond with 10. Qd2. If Black plays 10. exd5 we play 11. Bf4. When they move their queen to f6, we send the bishop back to g5. We repeat until a draw, or they put their queen on a bad square. Black has 3 options: Qh5, Qe6, and Qe7. By far the best is Qe7. This move gives us a very slight advantage of +0.06.

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 Qf6 7. Bd2 Nd4 8. h4 Bc5 9. Bg5 Qe5 10. Qd2 exd5 11. Bf4 Qe7 12. Be3

If Black moves the knight to c6, a mistake, we trade the bishops, and take the pawn on d5. With a pawn advantage we trade down and win the endgame. If they move the knight to e6 we take the pawn with the knight. We then develop normally, castle, and turn our +0.07 advantage into a win or a draw. Altogether it looks like this:

1.3.7: 9. Qe5, 12. Ne6

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 Qf6 7. Bd2 Nd4 8. h4 Bc5 9. Bg5 Qe5 10. Qd2 exd5 11. Bf4 Qe7 12. Be3 Ne6 13. Nxd5 Qd6

1.3.8: 9. Qe5, 12. Nc6

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 Qf6 7. Bd2 Nd4 8. h4 Bc5 9. Bg5 Qe5 10. Qd2 exd5 11. Bf4 Qe7 12. Be3 Nc6 13. Bxc5 Qxc5 14. exd5

1.3.9: 9. Qe6 and 9. Qh5

After Black moves the Queen to h5, we again play Be3. They put the knight on e6, and we take their pawn with our pawn. They must choose which piece they want to lose, the knight or the bishop.

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4
 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e6 6. d5 Qf6 7. Bd2 Nd4
 8. h4 Bc5 9. Bg5 Qe5 10. Qd2 exd5 11.
 Bf4 Qh5 12. Be3 Ne6 13. exd5 Bxe3 14.
 Qxe3

If they take our bishop, just take back with the queen and pin the knight, ensuring the gain of material. The reason why Qe7 was the best one is because it blocks this pin, meaning our tactic would have turned into a trade.

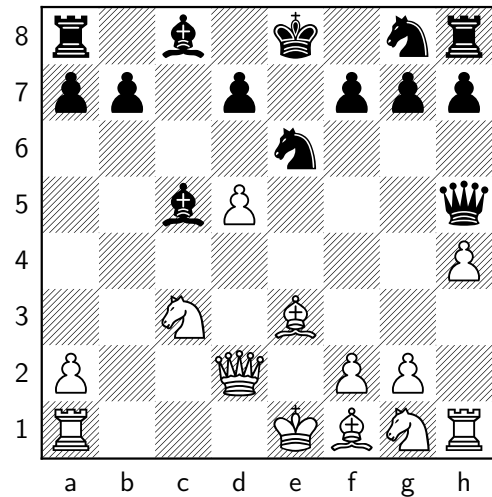


Figure 8: Black forced into a dilemma of which piece to give up.

2: Main Line: Pirc Variation

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4
 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6

We've taken a look at all of the e6 lines after Black takes the second pawn. Now we will look at Black's second response after taking the pawn, Black plays 5. d6 to set up 6. e5 and open up the light squared bishop, without the commitment of 5. d5.

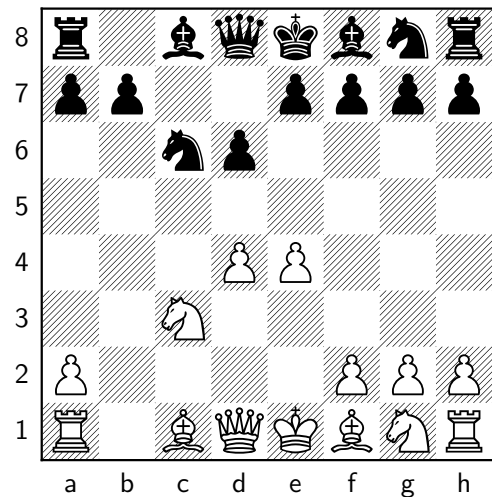


Figure 9: The Pirc Variation of the main line.

We should respond with d5, and after this line Black's best move is Nb8, but no one plays this. The most common move is 6. Ne5, and our response is to yet again attack the knight with 7. f4. The most common move after 7. f4, 7. Ng6, is a mistake. The second most common, 7. Nd7 is the best response.

2.1: 6. Ne5

If they play 6. Ne5 we respond with 7. f4 and keep kicking around their knight as in the e6 lines. The 2 continuations from 6. Ne5 are:

2.1.1: 7. Ng6

If Black plays Ng6, we respond with Bb5+. They must block with Bd7. We play Rb1. This move is very important because if we don't play it, Black responds by trading the bishops and playing Qa5+, forking our knight and winning 3 points of material. We don't play Rb1, or the other winning move, Ne2. Rb1 is better than Ne2 though.

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6 6. d5 Ne5 7. f4 Ng6 8. Bb5+  
Bd7 9. Nf3 Bxb5 10. Nxb5 Qa5+ 11. Bd2 Qxb5
```

Black is much better.

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6 6. d5 Ne5 7. f4 Ng6 8. Bb5+  
Bd7 9. Rb1
```

Black now can't fork with the queen because our rook is protecting the knight. Black's best reply is 9. Rc1. This line has only been played 2 times though, meaning very few people have played this. The 2 replies were trading the bishop with Bxb5 and Nf6. Taking back with the rook is best because we win tempo by threatening the pawn on b2. Unlike e6 lines our forking threat isn't scary because we can't play d6, protecting the knight and making a pin threat. From here if they play b6, the better move, we make use of our development to attack Black. If they defend the pawn with Rb8 we play Qa4, and threaten both pawns. We have strong attacking potential and a +4.2 advantage according to Stockfish.

2.1.2: 7. Nd7

7. Nd7 is Black's best try to defend against 7. f4 as it prevents 8. Bb5+ unlike 7. Ng6. From here, we play 8. Nf3, and they have 2 options from this point: The Pseudo Najdorf, which is almost required to lead to a "Dragondorf" setup, the Pseudo Dragon, which will not lead to a Dragondorf, and the Drunk Knight Variation, which is often paired with a dragon/najdorf, leading to a Drunk Najdorf, or Drunk Dragon, or even the Drunk Dragondorf.

2.2: Najdorf Variation

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6 6. d5 Ne5 7. f4 Nd7 8. Nf3 a6

Evaluation: 1.36 **Depth:** 40 Moves

Key Idea: Use the huge space advantage and central pawn wedge to cramp Black's development while preparing a kingside attack.

After 8. Nf3, Black plays a6 as in the Najdorf, controlling the b5 square, and preparing an eventual b5 pawn push.

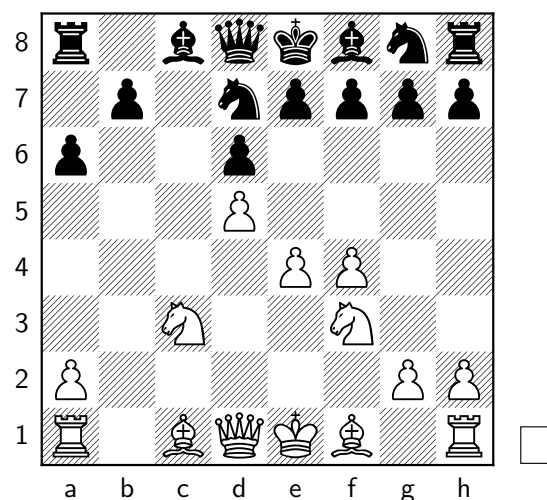


Figure 10: The Najdorf Variation of the Main Line

Unlike the Najdorf, Black has no plans to play e5 any time soon, as this is a major mistake due to our pawn on d5. We can now capture en passant, and use their lack of an f pawn to attack on the kingside with moves such as Ng5 as in this line:

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6 6. d5 Ne5 7. f4 Nd7 8. Nf3 a6 9. Be2 e5 10. dxe6 fxe6 11. Ng5

And White has attacking chances and is much better. We can capitalize on the d6 weakness, castle kingside, place our knights on d5 and e6, and play Bh5+ at some point.

So that is why Black can't play e5 in the Pseudo Najdorf. After 8. a6, we can play either 9. Be2 or 9. Be3. The idea of 9. Be2 is to castle quickly, and form a queen-bishop battery to create attacking chances on the kingside, focusing on h5. The idea of 9. Be3 is to block the c5 square from the knight, and to prevent any Qb6 ideas so White can safely castle.

After 9. Be2 we play 10. Be3, and after 9. Be3 we play 10. Be2. Our position is great, and Black has a hard time castling and being safe. Our position should look something like a Semi-Averbakh, and theirs should look like a King's Indian Defense. Their only hope for the dark squared bishop is to fianchetto and the knight's best square is f6.

2.3: Dragondorf Variation

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6 6. d5 Ne5 7. f4 Nd7 8. Nf3 a6 9. Be3 g6

After our plans in the Najdorf variation are complete, they may play g6. Black plans to fianchetto their dark squared bishop in a King's Indian like setup. We play 11. e5 to attack their knight and

claim more space in the center. They have a couple options from here.

2.3.1: Dragondorf, Trade Variation

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6 6. d5 Ne5 7. f4 Nd7 8. Nf3 a6
9. Be3 Ngf6 10. Be2 g6 11. e5 dxe5

After they take, we take back with 12. fxe5. They must move their knight, and they have 3 options. 12. Ng8 is completely antithetical to their whole purpose in moving the knight to f6, which is castling. After 12. Ng8 we play 13. e6, and all knight moves are a mistake. If they play 13. Ng8, then they have zero development. All their pieces are standing on the back rank, and their position is dreadful. We play 14. Exf7+ and they are forced to lose castling rights and put their king in an awful situation. Checkmate will come quickly either way they choose to move their king. If they play 13. Ndf6 we play 14. Qh4+. They must respond with 14. Bd8, and we win a bishop.

So it is clear that moving the knight after 13. e6 is not an option. Their only try to save the position is 13. Bh6, but that falls to 14. exd7. After they take back, we can play 15. Bd4, and they must block with 15. Nf6. We castle, and they castle. After this we play 17. Qb3 and target the pawn on b7. We enjoy a great position, while up a pawn and threatening to widen the gap, and with attacking potential. We have a +3.8 advantage according to Stockfish.

So 12. Ng8 isn't an option for Black. 12. Nh5 is bad for the exact same reasons as 12. Ng8, and the same traps still work in this variation.

12. Ng4 is the only option for Black that doesn't immediately lose. We play 13. Bd4, and if they play 13. Bg7 we can win material with the discovered attack, 14. e6. They can save material with 14. Ne5, but 15. exf7 puts their king in a very dangerous position. From here we castle, attack, and hunt their king.

So that's how to win in the Pseudo Dragon, Trade Variation. Next up, we will look at if they ignore the threat on their knight and counterattack with 11. Qa5.

2.3.2: Dragondorf, Qa5 Variation

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6 6. d5 Ne5 7. f4 Nd7 8. Nf3 a6
9. Be3 Ngf6 10. Be2 g6 11. e5 Qa5

Qa5 is the best idea for Black, attacking our weak c3 knight. But if they play Qa5, we can put the bishop on d2, protecting it. If they fianchetto the dark squared bishop, we play Rc1 to add extra protection, and continue on with our plans. If they play Qb6, we can play Na4, and they have to place their queen on either d8 or a7, both inactive and unuseful squares. If they play Qa7, we play Qc2, and if they play Qd8 we play e5. We have strong attacking potential, a huge space advantage, a much stronger bishop pair, and better king safety.

2.3.3: Drunk Najdorf Variation

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6 6. d5 Ne5 7. f4 Nd7 8. Nf3 Nh6 9. Be3 a6 10. h3

The Drunk Najdorf can be reached either by 8. a6 followed by 9. Nh6, or by 8. Nh6 followed by 9. a6. In the Drunk Najdorf, our 10th move should be 10. h3. This prevents any pinning of our knight on f3, as well as prevents the knight on h6 from jumping into our territory, and attacking our bishop on e3, winning tempo and putting the knight in a good position to attack us. The 3 continuations that we will look at are the Drunk Dragonorf, the Qa5 variation, and the Nc5 variation.

2.3.4: Drunk Dragonorf Variation

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6 6. d5 Ne5 7. f4 Nd7 8. Nf3 Nh6 9. Be3 a6 10. h3 g6

The Drunk Dragonorf is the combination of the Najdorf, Dragon, and Drunk Knight lines. After 10. g6 we play 11. Qd4. Their only 2 moves are 11. f3, and 11. Rg8. We will look at 11. Rg8 first.

This move gives up Black's kingside castling rights, and from the position of their light squared bishop, they won't be castling queen-side anytime soon. 11. Rg8 sets up 12. Bg7, and our response is 12. Qb4.

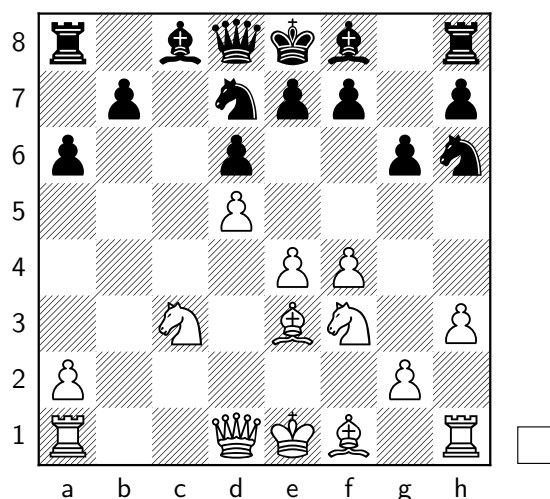


Figure 11: The Drunk Dragonorf Variation, inspired by the Dragon, Najdorf, and Drunk Knight openings.

We have to protect the knight this turn as if we moved our queen completely away from the knight, the bishop would develop while attacking, losing tempo. While this isn't the worst thing in the world, it is better to focus on quick development.

Black's best move after 12. Qb4 is 12. Bg7, fianchettoing the bishop, and applying pressure to our weak knight on c3. We can respond with either 13. Be2 or 13. Rc1, and be just fine. From here, we have a strong position, a bishop pair, a huge space advantage, and even attacking potential in some cases.

2.3.5: Drunk Najdorf, Qa5 Variation

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6 6. d5 Ne5 7. f4 Nd7 8. Nf3 Nh6 9. Be3 a6 10. h3 Qa5

Our best defense of the knight on c3 is 11. Bd4. This not only defends the knight, but prevents a kingside fianchetto for Black, and preparing attacks. The loss of the ability to fianchetto means

that both of Black's bishops are horrendous, trapped on the back rank by their own pawns. Black's only hope for the bishop is playing 11. f3. After 11. f3 we play 12. Nd2, unpinning the Knight on c3. They can play 12. g6, making the Delayed Drunk Dragondorf system. We play 13. Nc4, forcing the queen to an inactive square. If they play 13. Qb4?? we can play 14. a3, trapping the queen.

After they move their queen, we play 14. a4, claiming space on the queenside and preparing 15. a5. After they play 14. Bg7, we can play 15. a5, taking advantage of the hole on b6. From here, Black can castle, and we can prepare the outpost with 16. Na4. On the next turn we can officially claim the powerful outpost with 17. Ncb6. Our position is better, and despite being down a pawn, our position is evaluated at +1.8.

2.3.6: Drunk Najdorf, Nc5 Variation

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6 6. d5 Ne5 7. f4 Nd7 8. Nf3
Nh6 9. Be3 a6 10. h3 Nc5
```

The Nc5 variation looks good for Black, as it claims an outpost which could be useful in the future. But, this variation lets us reveal the other intention behind our h3 move. We push our pawn with 11. g4, starting a kingside pawn storm and claiming even more space. All our kingside pawns are advanced, while Black doesn't have a piece in our territory at all!

Against this variation, against 11. g6, we play 12. g5, and their knight is forced back to g8, or they must counterattack with 12. Qa5. 13. Qd4 is the best move here because it protects the vulnerable e4 pawn, which would be hanging due to the knight being pinned. It also protects our knight. The third thing it does is attack Black's rook on h8. If their best course of action is to take your pawn with 13. Nxe4. They can also play 13. Rg8, but then we take the knight, and we are valued at +3 after:

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6 6. d5 Ne5 7. f4 Nd7 8. Nf3
Nh6 9. Be3 a6 10. h3 Nc5 11. g4 g6 12. g5 Qa5 13. Qd4 Rg8 14. gxh6 Nxe4 15. Qxe4
Qxc3+ 16. Kf2
```

If they take our undefended pawn with 13. Nxe4, we can capture the rook with 14. Qxh8. 14. Nxc3 is worse than 14. Qxc3, because after 15. Bd2 Qxe5 16. Qxc3 Nf5 17. Rc1 we are up material and have a better position. If they play 14. Qxc3, we can play 15. Qxc3 Nxc3 16. gxh6 Nxd5 17. Bd2 Bxh6 18. Ng5. We are up material and have a better position, and if they kick our knight with 18. f3, we can counterattack with 19. Bg2. From here, our rooks can neutralize Black's pawns, which haven't crossed the 6th rank since move 4.

2.3.7: Drunk Knight Variation

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6 6. d5 Ne5 7. f4 Nd7 8. Nf3
Nh6
```

The Drunk Knight Variation is marked by 8. Nh6. This odd looking move is actually the second best move for Black, after the Najdorf Variation. The idea of placing the knight on the rim is to prevent it from being harassed by our pawn on f4. From here we play 9. Be3. Black's options are the Drunk Najdorf, and a Drunk Dragon variations.

2.3.8: Dragon Variation

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6 6. d5 Ne5 7. f4 Nd7 8. Nf3 g6

In the Dragon Variation, we play Qd4 immediately. This is a flexible and multi purpose move. First of all, it prevents Qa5 winning tempo, second, it develops while attacking the Black rook, and third, it prevents 9. Bg7. 9. Ngf6 is fine for Black, as after 10. e5, they have 2 options. 10. dxe5, and the surprising 10. Bg7.

After 11. fxe5, Black's best move is to play 11. Bg7. The reason for sacrificing the knight is that if Black doesn't sacrifice the knight, it will be forced onto g7. This knight is trapped on the g7 square, and this means the bishop is locked into the f8, Black's castling plans are ruined, and Black's whole position is slow and painful to play. We are valued at +4.4 if they save their knight.

If Black saves the knight:

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6 6. d5 Ne5 7. f4 Nd7 8. Nf3 g6
9. Qd4 Ngf6 10. e5 dxe5 11. fxe5 Nh5 12. g4 Ng7 13. Rb1 a6 14. Bg2

After sacrificing the knight, we can develop normally, like this: 1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6 6. d5 Ne5 7. f4 Nd7 8. Nf3 g6 9. Qd4 Ngf6 10. e5 dxe5 11. fxe5 Bg7 12. exf6 Bxf6 13. Qb4 O-O 14. Be3 Ne5 15. Nxe5 Bxe5 16. Bd4 Bxd4 17. Qxd4 Bf5 18. Be2 And White is winning.

2.3.9: Summary of 6. Ne5:

6. Ne5 leads to some fun lines that are reminiscent of popular Open Sicilian variations, and new and fun lines which look weird, but all 6. Ne5 variations give White a large advantage, even with near perfect play.

2.3.10: 6. Nb8

This line is far better for Black than 6. Ne5 because the knight on b8 can easily defend our threats which it could not defend against in the previous line. From here we play f4, focusing on controlling the center with pawns. We must play sharply to secure the win.

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d6 6. d5 Na5 7. Be3 Bd7 8. Nf3
e5 9. dxe6 fxe6 10. Be2 Nf6 11. O-O

Example development.

2.3.11: 6. Nb4

This is a blunder because it allows 8. Qa4 to fork and there is nothing Black can do. If they block with the knight, we play 9. Bb5. When they play 9. Bb7 we take with the pawn and Black is losing.

2.3.12: 6. Na5

This isn't a blunder, but it is a mistake. We can continue with either 7. Be3 or 7. Nf3 and enjoy a comfortable position. Their knight is trapped on the edge of the board, and they must play b6 at some point to free it. From here, focus on controlling the center, developing, and castling early.

3: Main Line: King's Fianchetto Defense

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 g6

Evaluation: 0.25 **Depth:** 40 Moves

Key Idea: Capitalize on your massive space advantage and development to launch a deadly attack on the kingside with your pawns.

The King's Fianchetto Defense is a setup reminiscent of an English Opening setup, with a fianchettoed bishop and a knight controlling central dark squares with pieces.

The only problem is, there is no pawn on c5 to control the d4 square, meaning our pawn is already placed to kick out Black's knight. After 6. d5, we attack the knight, but Black can play 6. Bg7, attacking our weak knight on c3. Capturing our opponent's knight is not an option as when Black takes our knight with check, they win the rook as well. So we must respond carefully to the threat of our knights. Another idea of the King's Fianchetto Defense is to bring the queen to a5, adding pressure to our knight. To try to avoid this, we play 7. Bd2, defending our knight and if the Black queen navigates to h5, removing the absolute pin of the knight. The relative pin from the bishop is still a problem for us however.

Black is now forced to save their knight, as if they play 7. Qh5, we play 8. Rc1, and if they save their knight now with 8. Nb4, we can play 9. Nb5. We threaten to fork their king and rook, and if they defend this threat with 9. Rb8, we play 10. a3, winning the knight through the bishop's pin. If they save their knight with anything other than 8. Nb4, we can play 9. Nb5, and win material with the discovered attack, and the fork. There is nothing Black can do to prevent the loss of material. So Black cannot execute their plan of Qh5 yet. Now let's look at the potential knight moves.

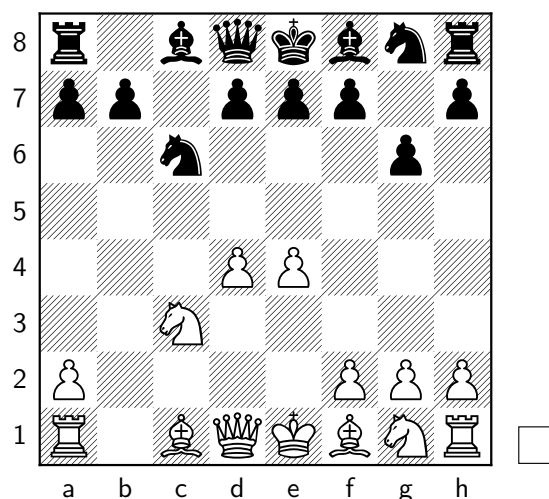


Figure 12: The King's Fianchetto Defense

3.1: 7. Ne5

This is a blunder because after 8. f4, the knight is completely trapped. For some reason, it is also the most common move.

3.2: 7. Nd4

After 7. Nd4 we play 8. Rc1 to centralize the rook and add further protection to the weak c3 knight. Black's best move from here is 8. d6, but the most obvious move, at least to me, is 8. Nf6, which is a mistake. We play 9. e6, and their knight is forced to either g8 or h5. If they play 9. Nh5, we can play g4, and their knight is completely trapped. If instead of 9. Nh5 they play 9. Ng8, we play 10. Bf4, and this traps their knight on d4! Their best move is 10. g5 but after 11. Be3 Nf5 12. Bxg5 Bxe5 13. Nf3 Bg7?? 14. Nb5 Rb8 15. g4 h6 16. Bf4 Nd6 17. Nxd6+ exd6 18. Bxd6 Ra8 19. Qe2+ Ne7 20. Bc7 we win the queen, and with all obvious and reasonable looking moves from Black. So that is why 8. Nf6 is a mistake.

The other choice, 8. d6 is a very sound move. After 9. Be3, their knight can only be defended with 9. Qb6 and 9. e5. 9. Qb6 is a blunder because after 10. Nb5, we threaten the protected fork once again, and the Black knight that would defend the fork is pinned to the queen. So 9. e5 is the only option. But now we take an en passant, and they must recapture with the knight or lose material.

After this Black has an alright position, and we can still threaten the fork with 11. Nb5. They can play 11. a6, because the knight on e6 protects c7. Now we can win back our pawn and force Black to lose castling rights with 12. Nxd6. 12. Ke7! Is the only move that doesn't lose material. 13. Nc4 Qxd1 14. Rxd1 is the continuation of 12. Ke7 and we have an alright position.

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 g6 6. d5 Bg7 7. Bd2 Nd4 8. Rc1 d6 9. Be3 e5 10. dxe6 Nxe6 11. Nb5 a6 12. Nxd6+ Kf8 13. Nf3 Nf6 14. Bc4 Bd7 15. 0-0

12. Kd7 is a blunder because after 13. Nxb7 we win the queen with a discovered attack. Similarly 12. Kc8 is a mistake because it leads to a cramped and space deficient position for Black, while we get great development. The line above and illustrated on the right shows my point well.

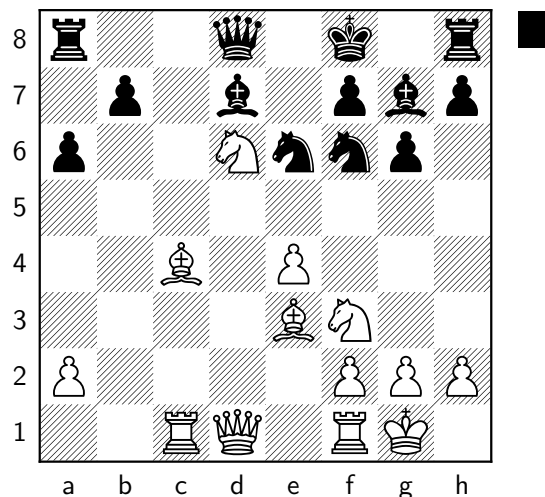


Figure 13: White dominates in space and development while Black suffers from a cramped position.

3.3: 7. Nb4

7. Nb4 is a mistake for Black as after 8. Rc1 Na6 9. Bxa6 bxa6 10. d6 exd6 11. Nge2 they have 2 doubled isolated pawns, a bad light square bishop, and no control over the open b file. Overall, we are much better positionally than Black and we control the board.

3.4: 7. Na5

From here, we play 8. Rc1 to further fortify the knight and explore similar attacking ideas as the Ne5 line. Black only has one reasonable move, here, which is 8. a6. To prevent Nb5 and a fork. Any other move puts Black at a significant disadvantage due to the pressure White puts on c7.

3.5: 7. Nb8

From here our response is 8. d6, and the obvious move here is 8. exd6 however 9. Nb5 immediately puts White at an advantage as Black has no way to defend the d6 pawn and c7 as well. If Black attempts to use the queen to defend d6 then 10. Rc1 gives powerful attacking opportunities on c7.

4: Main Line: King's Pawn Defense

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 e5

Evaluation: 0.00 **Depth:** 50 Moves

Key Ideas: Utilize the open queenside files and the g file and a3 and a4 diagonals to attack Black aggressively, or play a standard and safe midgame by castling kingside and focusing on position.

Our best response here is 6. dxe5 and Black will take back with Nxe5. Then, our best move is 7. Nf3. From here, Black has a few options to defend their knight.

4.1: 7. Nxf3+

This is the straightforward line where Black trades knights. Contrary to classical chess wisdom, both 8. gxf3 and 8. Qxf3 are rated similarly at +0.3 for White. However, the queen is to be preferred if one seeks a more traditional opening. Taking with the queen, White should play a standard game, wanting to play Bc4 and potentially Bg5 and castling kingside. For a more aggressive game, one can play 9. Bf4 against Black's Bd6, castle kingside, aim for Bc4, and play down the queenside files with the queen's rook. 8. gxf3 leads to more focus on queenside aggressive play as White forgoes castling. Against 8. Bb4 White plays 9. Qb3 and can exploit the queenside diagonals later with Ba3. If Black plays 8. Nf6, White can use the open kingside g file to attack with 9. Rg1 and later Rb1.

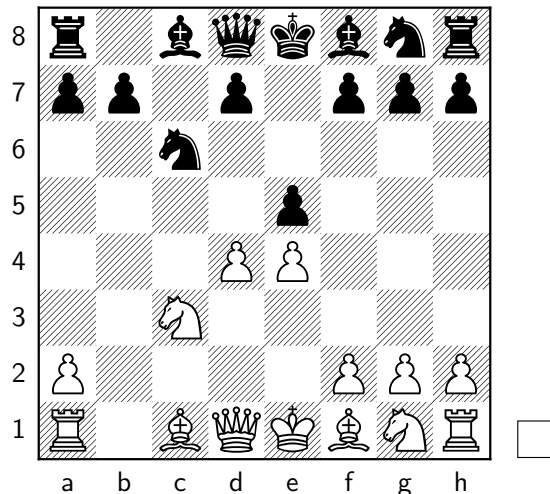


Figure 14: The King's Pawn Defense of the Main Line.

4.2: 7. d6

White has a significant advantage against d6 with 8. Bb5+ which lets White castle kingside and exploit Black's critically underdeveloped kingside to eventually attack with Qa4 and the open files. The a4-e8 diagonal is particularly thematic in this line.

4.3: 7. f6

7. f6 is a critically bad move for Black allowing 8. Nxe5 and if Black recaptures with the pawn, 9. Qh5+ introduces typical scholar's mate ideas. If Black instead plays 8. Qa5, forking the knights, we should respond with the seemingly insane 9. Nf7 and if Black takes with the king we will play 10. Bc4 and introduce scholar's mate ideas to punish their mistake.

4.4: 7. Qe7

We can reply with 8. Nd5 and threaten the fork on c7. If Black checks with Nxf3+ we can take with the queen and when Black plays Qe5, 10. Rb1 exploits the terminally weak Black queenside. If Black does not check we can add pressure to their knight with 9. Bf4 and we will eventually win their knight with accurate play.

5: Main Line: 2 Knights Defense

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 Nf6

Evaluation: 0.96 **Depth:** 40 Moves

Key Ideas: Push around Black's knights with d5, e5, a3, f4, etc. and capture a massive space and development advantage to punish Black's risky knight placement.

This line has been played, although very rarely. It is easy to see why: our pawns are in prime position to push around Black's knights. We should play d5 as e5 is a major blunder here.

We should respond to Ne5 with f4 and aim to claim a massive portion of the board while pushing around both of Black's knights. We should respond to Na5 with e5. We should respond to Black's most accurate line of play, Nb4, with 7. a3 and later e5. We can continue with standard play here because Black's position has already completely fallen. Stockfish puts White at a +1 advantage and it is easy to see why.

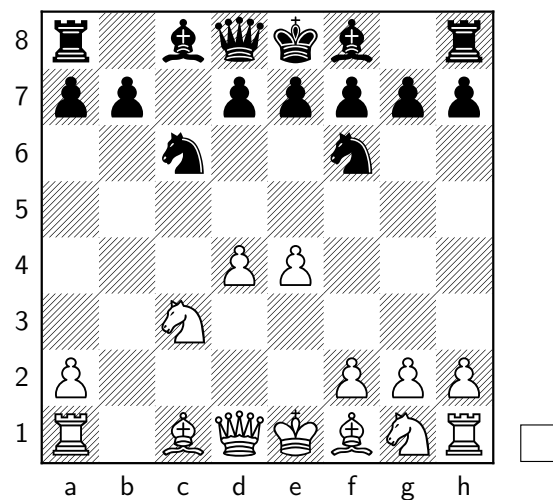


Figure 15: The 2 Knights Defense of the Main Line

6: Main Line: Queen's Pawn Defense

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 d5

Evaluation: 2.58 **Depth:** 20 Moves

Key Ideas: Punish Black's undefended pawn and play normally with a massive position advantage.

Although this seems reasonable, this is a major blunder on Black's behalf and 6. exd5 reveals why. Black will play Na5 and we respond with 7. Bb5+, capturing Black's bishop when they block with it.

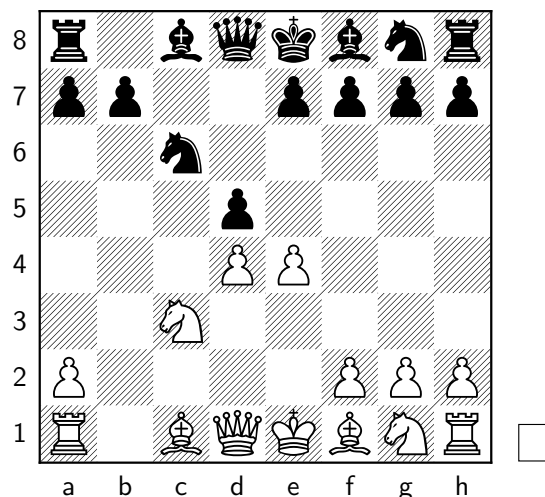


Figure 16: The Queen's Pawn Defense of the Main Line

Then, we will play 9. Nf3 and aim to put the knight on the square e5. Black's best response is f3, however a more standard choice gives White an enormous tactical advantage. With thoughtful play, White can easily win against this response.

7: Main Line: Wayward Queen Attack

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 bxc3 5. Nxc3 Qa5

Evaluation: 1.18 **Depth:** 30 Moves

Key Ideas: Defend with Bd2 and use your improve bishop mobility for a tactical advantage. Focus on attacking the queenside.

Black attempts to scare us here with Qa5, however 6. Bd2 quickly neutralizes this. If Black decides to play Nxd4 to take the "hanging" pawn, we can play 7. Nce2 for a double attack.

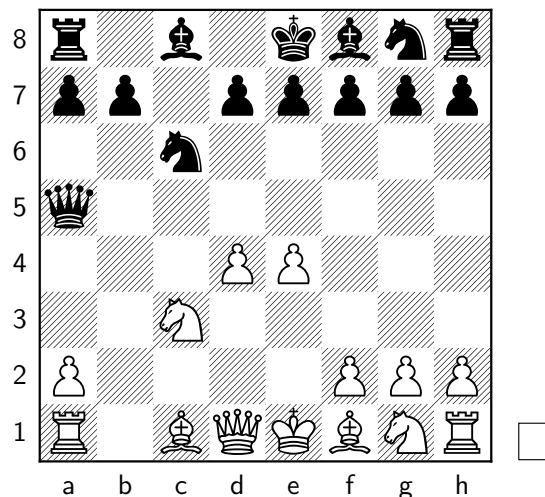


Figure 17: The Wayward Queen Attack of the Main Line

From here, White can exploit their improved bishop openness and play for a tactical advantage. However, if Black does not play Nxd4, we can aim our focus on d5 by either putting the knight there or pushing the pawn there. This gives White many powerful queenside attacking opportunities and a tactical advantage can be won with smart play.

Part III

Main Line: 4. d5

These lines are uncommon though they present Black's two best ways to play after we take d4. We will not cover them in the same detail due to their rareness however.

1: 4. d5

From here, White should play 5. a3 and Black has three significant responses, being bxa3, bxc3, and dxe4. We explore them in detail here.

1.1: 5. bxa3

From here, we should play 6. exd5 Qxd5 7. Nxa3 and aim to establish a strong knight-focused presence in the center, and castling kingside. This line presents a position of +0.4 for White and gives White a fun, open position. This line has a valuation of +0.4 which leads to sharp queenside play in certain scenarios.

1.2: 5. bxc3

This line is Black's best option, and White is at a disadvantage here of -0.7. Our best course of action is 6. Nxc3 dxe4 7. d5 and we hope to castle kingside. A typical line here would look like

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 d5 5. a3 bxc3 6. Nxc3 dxe4 7. d5 Nb8 8. Bb5+  
Nd7 9. Nge2 Nf6 10. O-O g6 11. Ng3 Bg7 12. Rb1 O-O
```

which opens to a sharp middlegame where both sides have sharp attacking ideas, White on the queenside and Black on the kingside. Black has a King's Indian-like structure however lacks the queenside fortifications the typical King's Indian has, and thus White is presented with good queenside attacking themes.

1.3: 5. dxe4

Here, our line will look something like:

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 d5 5. a3 dxe4 6. axb4 Nf6 7. Nd2 g6 8. Bc4  
Bg7 9. Ne2
```

with defensive play on both sides due to the central pawn structure. Indeed this line is very sharp with a 0.7 favor on Black but this can be easily lost, and Stockfish seems to draw against itself when playing from this line frequently.

Part IV

Main Line: 4. e6

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6
```

Stockfish says that we have two nearly identically valued responses here, being 5. a3 and 5. d5. We will cover both in detail as although they are rated similarly, they play very differently and some may prefer one to another. From games of Stockfish playing against itself, a3 tends to result in a sharp yet safe middlegame that reduces to a technical endgame where one mistake can lead to a loss. From games of Stockfish playing against itself, d5 tends to result in a highly dangerous attacking middlegame that will often end with checkmate, although at higher levels a technical endgame can be reached.

1: 5. a3 Line

In this line, we respond to e6 with a3, and Black has 4 obvious options: taking our c pawn, taking our a pawn, playing Qa5, or playing d5. We will discuss each line.

1.1: bxc3 Line

This line is Black's best response against our gambit as a whole, leaving us at a -0.7 valuation after a standard line:

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4  
e6 5. a3 bxc3 6. Nxc3 d5 7. Nf3 dxe4  
8. Nxe4 Nf6 9. Bd3 Be7 10. 0-0 0-0
```

Evaluation: -0.68 **Depth:** 30 Moves

Key Ideas: Attack down the queenside with Rb1 and Qc2 or focus on precise play for a winnable endgame.

However, our position is still highly playable and lazy defense from Black results in a devastating queenside attack. Overall, for a worst-case scenario, this is a much safer position than most gambits will leave you in if the opponent happens to know the theory.

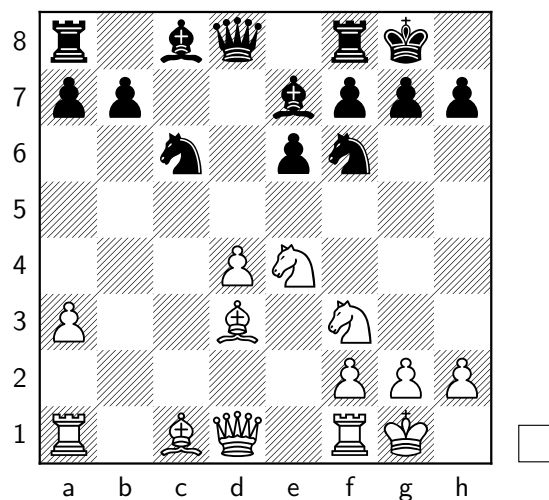


Figure 18: Black's optimal play after accepting the gambit, resulting in a playable middlegame position.

1.2: bxa3 Line

Capturing the a pawn here reduces Black's advantage to almost nothing. We have two options here, both valued almost equally. However, both versions eventually end up playing the other's move, so we will not cover them individually.

We will want to play Nxa3 to recapture the pawn, and Bd3 soon as well. We will aim to play d5 or e5 and we want to push around Black's knights while cramping their development. The choice of which to do first does not matter here, as Black's pawn is all but doomed.

One important caveat is to avoid Nf3 but instead play Nh3. At first it seems insane, but upon closer inspection, this move captures more space than Nf3, and will set the way for a kingside attack. Later we should play f4 and attempt a kingside pawn storm. An example game would be:

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6 5. a3 bxa3 6. Bd3 Nf6 7. Nxa3 d5 8. e5 Nd7
9. Nh3 Be7 10. O-O a6 11. Nc2 Rb8 12. f4
```

White has significantly better attacking chances as well as a huge space and rapid development compared to Black's cramped position.

1.3: Qa5 Line

We will respond to Black's extra pressure on c3 with Bb2. An example line is:

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6 5. a3 Qa5 6. Bb2 bxc3 7. Bxc3 Qc7 8. d5
Ne5 9. Nf3 Nxf3+ 10. Qxf3
```

This leads to a very balanced midgame where White is down material but has space and development in return. White should aim to attack queenside while Black will attack kingside.

1.4: d5 Line

This is another very sharp position where Black and White are rated evenly. Our next move should be exd5 followed by axb4, and a typical line will look like

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6 5. a3 d5 6. exd5 exd5 7. axb4 Bd6 8. Bd3
h6 9. Nf3 Nf6 10. O-O O-O
```

White should play the midgame carefully and cautiously attack down the middle and queensides.

2: 5. d5 Line

This line typically reduces to a standard yet sharp midgame, with a typical line of

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6 5. d5 exd5 6. exd5 Ne5 7. a3 bxc3 8. Nxc3 d6 9. Nf3 Nxf3+ 10. Qxf3 Nf6 11. Bb5+ Bd7 12. O-O Be7 13. h3 O-O

White should play for a winning endgame and avoid overzealous attacks, as Black is safe but underdeveloped here. Black has two main responses here: exd5, and Ne5.

2.1: d5 Attack: exd5 Line

If Black decides to capture our d5 pawn with their e6 pawn, we will recapture with 6. exd5 which continues to threaten Black's knight. From here, Black has only two good options: Ne5, and Qe7+. Ne5 is better for Black, however aggressive players may respond with Qe7+, and we will consider both lines in detail.

2.1.1: d5 Attack: exd5 Line: Ne5 Retreat

From here we play 7. a3 (it is worth noting that 7. Nf3 and 7. Be2 are close behind a3 in valuation. Both lead to a more standard game than a3).

7. Nf3: 1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6 5. d5 exd5 6. exd5 Ne5 7. Nf3 Nxf3+ 8. Qxf3 Nf6 9. Bd3 Bd6 10. O-O O-O

7. Be2: 1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6 5. d5 exd5 6. exd5 Ne5 7. Be2 Nf6 8. Nf3 Bd6 9. O-O O-O

Both of these lines are highly sharp and lead to a tight middlegame. For players seeking a slightly better rated but more difficult and unorthodox game, a3 is to be preferred:

7. a3: 1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6 5. d5 exd5 6. exd5 Ne5 7. a3 bxc3 8. Nxc3 Nf6 9. f4 Ng6 10. Qe2+ Qe7 11. Be3

This is an aggressive line and White should aim to attack the queenside with Rc1 and the kingside with f4 and later g3 and h3.

2.1.2: d5 Attack: exd5 Line: Qe7+ Attack

Blocking the check with 7. Be2 is strongly preferred here, and this is a relatively “trappy” move. Any move for Black other than Ne5 is a significant mistake, as this allows Nf3 and White to completely dominate the center with Black's development stifled. If Black does play Ne5, there are three main lines we will discuss.

f4: This is a highly aggressive attack and can lead to a positional advantage, though a mistake here may be fatal due to White's exposed king. A typical line can look like:

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6 5. d5 exd5 6. exd5 Qe7+ 7. Be2 Ne5 8. f4
Ng4 9. Nf3 N8f6 10. Qd3 Qe4 11. h3 Nh6 12. a3
```

with White to focus on a pawn-based attack on the kingside and absolute control of the center.

Nh3: This is another highly aggressive line although it is much safer for White than f4. A standard line will look like:

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6 5. d5 exd5 6. exd5 Qe7+ 7. Be2 Ne5 8. Nh3
d6 9. O-O Bxh3 10. gxh3 Nf6 11. Bb5+ Kd8 12. f4 Ng6
```

and both sides will attack, White on the queenside, Black on the kingside.

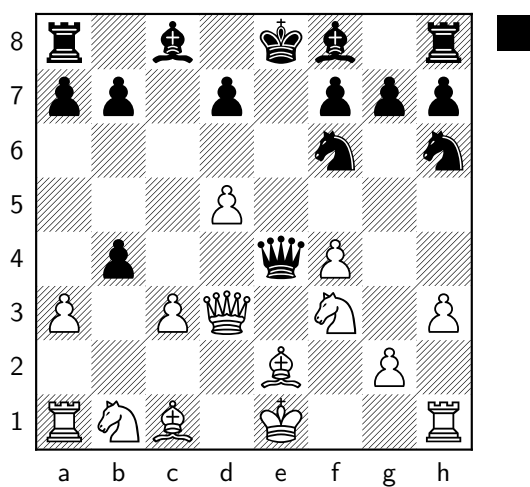


Figure 19: A highly aggressive line with 8. f4 leading to a pawn attack on the kingside.

Another standard version of the Nh3 line is:

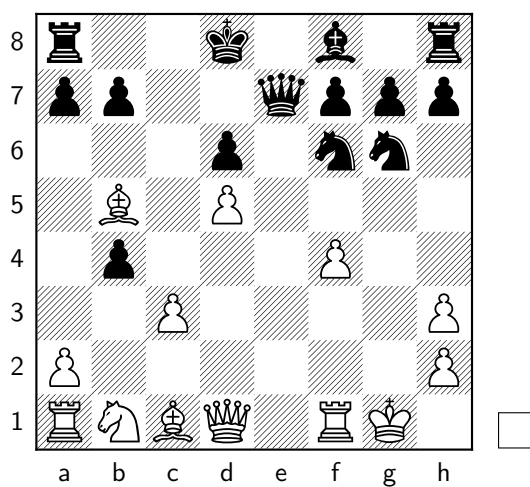


Figure 20: Another highly aggressive line with 8. Nh3 to capture space.

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6 5. d5 exd5 6. exd5 Qe7+ 7. Be2 Ne5 8. Nh3
Nf6 9. O-O Qc5 10. Nf4 bxc3 11. Qb3 Qb6 12. Nxc3
```

a3: In this position, Black's best move is b3, and here do not make the mistake of Qxb3 as Black can play a nice trick with Nd3+ and they will win a bishop or a rook. In this scenario, White should play similarly to the Nh3 line with:

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6 5. d5 exd5 6. exd5 Qe7+ 7. Be2 Ne5 8. a3
b3 9. Nh3 d6 10. O-O Bxh3 11. gxh3
```

If Black does not respond with b3 but instead bxc3, we can respond with an aggressive center attack:

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6 5. d5 exd5 6. exd5 Qe7+ 7. Be2 Ne5 8. a3
bxc3 9. Nxc3 a6 10. f4 Ng6 11. Nf3
```

And if Black plays bxa3, we can secure a huge positional advantage:

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6 5. d5 exd5 6. exd5 Qe7+ 7. Be2 Ne5 8. a3
bxa3 9. Nxa3 d6 10. Nb5 a6 11. f4 Nc4 12. Qd4
```

Finally, if Black does not take or push their b4 pawn, we can play in an unorthodox manner with a line like

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6 5. d5 exd5 6. exd5 Qe7+ 7. Be2 Ne5 8. a3
d6 9. axb4 g6 10. Nf3 Nxf3+ 11. gxf3 Bg7 12. O-O
```

Overall, this response is very tricky and Black has many opportunities for mistakes with little opportunities to punish White despite our seemingly blatant disregard for king safety.

2.1.3: Ne5 Line

In this line our opponent attempts to take more of the center by placing their knight on e5 and hoping to play safely and capitalize on their pawn advantage. However, we can respond with aggressive pawn play with 6. f4 forcing Ng6. A standard line will look like

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6 5. d5 Ne5 6. f4 Ng6 7. d6 Qa5 8. e5 bxc3 9.
Qd4 f6 10. Nf3 Nh6 11. Bd3 Nf7 12. Qxc3 Qxc3+ 13. Nxc3
```

And this gives us a massive space advantage and opportunities to attack Black on the queenside while crushing their kingside with pawns. Our main ideas in the Ne5 line are to play f4 and try to capture a space advantage while baiting Black into taking our c3 pawn. If Black decides to try to counter our pawn chain with f3, we can respond in a way similar to this:

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6 5. d5 Ne5 6. f4 Ng6 7. d6 Qa5 8. e5 f6 9.
cxb4 Qxb4+ 10. Bd2 Qe4+ 11. Ne2 fxe5 12. Nc3 Qc6 13. Rc1 Bxd6
```

Where we attack Black's kingside while avoiding castling.

2.1.4: Na5 Retreat

In this line, we will capitalize on our space advantage and sacrifice another pawn for rapid development and attacking ideas on the queenside:

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4 e6 5. d5 Na5 6. Nf3 Nf6 7. Bd3 exd5 8. exd5  
Nxd5 9. 0-0
```

This results in a technical middlegame where both sides must play precisely for an advantage, and White can achieve an advantage in many ways, eventually reducing to a winning endgame.

2.2: d5 Attack: Ne5 Line

Black attempts to capture more space here, but f4 quickly counters this. White should soon play d6 and try to play h4 and e5, launching a pawn attack on the kingside and exploiting their space advantage. If you do not enjoy dangerous attacking games, a safer progression still beginning with f4 here may look like:

```
1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nc6 3. b4 cxb4 4. d4  
e6 5. d5 Ne5 6. f4 Ng6 7. d6 Qa5 8.  
e5 Nxe5 9. fxe5 Qxe5+ 10. Be2 Qxd6 11.  
Qxd6 Bxd6 12. Nf3 Nf6 13. c4 a6 14.  
a3 bxa3 15. Bxa3 Bxa3 16. Rxa3 0-0 17.  
0-0
```

Evaluation: 0.27 **Depth:** 30 Moves

Key Ideas: Capture center space and try to attack along the b file. Aim for a winning endgame.

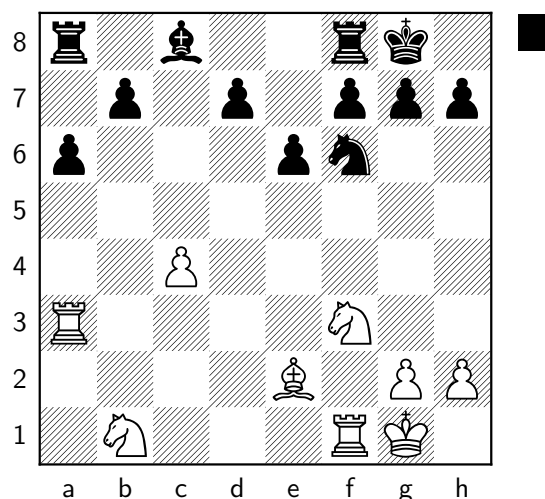


Figure 21: A safe late-midgame for White, but not without attacking ideas.

Part V

Conclusion & Bibliography

In the end, this gambit is about forcing Black into unfamiliar positions where every move matters and where White's space, development, and attacking chances can become overwhelming. The gambit's core features are rapid development, space, tactical chances, and pressure on Black's awkward pieces, and it is variationally rich enough to respond to Black's defenses. This opening is risky, unusual, but playable; it rewards preparation and punishes lazy defense heavily. It is best used by a player who wants initiative, chaos, and a fight from move three. With careful preparation, this gambit becomes a surprise weapon and deeply creative way to play against the Sicilian.

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